



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

DATA FROM the California Mobility Index list show that it takes former low- and moderate-income students from top-ranked Cal State L.A., above, less than nine months on average to recoup their educational costs.

CSUs rank at top for upward mobility

UCLA, Stanford do not make the best 10 list in state for raising socioeconomic status.

By DANIEL MILLER

Marco Florez knows the value of his California State University education because it changed his family's trajectory.

His mother, Suehey Florez, immigrated to the U.S. from Mexico "not knowing a lick of English," he said, but was able to attend Fresno State, where she earned bachelor's and master's degrees. She is now a special education teacher for the Tulare County Office of Education.

"One of the biggest things that transformed her life was getting that education," Florez said.

For Florez, 22, Fresno State was an easy choice because it is "really, really affordable," and it sets up immigrant and second-generation students for success, he said. Florez will graduate debt-free this year because of a Reserve Officers' Training Corps scholarship he received from the U.S. Army.

"A lot of people like to think of Fresno State as a stepping stone," he said. "But I think of it as a sky-rocket."

The Florez family's experience [See **Mobility**, A6]

Industry ties, fires add to pressure on Lara

Blazes raise issue of whether insurance chief and state have done enough to protect homeowners

By Laurence Darmiento

It has been more than a month since the harrowing wildfire swept through Pacific Palisades, and Marc Hara knows he should be grateful.

After all, he and his fiancée managed to escape the blaze that leveled their condominium complex. But Hara, who is living at a relative's house, is far from sanguine about his future.

Not only were all his possessions destroyed, but Hara also figures the couple is out \$170,000 after State Farm dropped him as a policyholder — something he learned only later, he said, after realizing the insurer mailed a nonrenewal notice for his interior coverage to an old address.

"My home is completely gone. We have absolutely nothing left," said the 58-year-old physical therapist, who had recently remodeled his condominium and is now

seeking FEMA disaster assistance. "I'm so screwed."

Citing privacy policies, State Farm declined to discuss Hara's situation, other than noting that it sends nonrenewal notices in advance to the address it has on record for policyholders.

The frustrations voiced by Hara echo those of many other homeowners in the Pacific Palisades and Eaton fire neighborhoods who were dropped by their insurers as companies retreated from fire-prone areas. Some homeowners enrolled in the state's insurer of last resort with more limited coverage. Others, such as Hara, might have had no coverage at all or couldn't afford to pay higher premiums.

The devastation caused by the twin blazes has [See **Lara**, A10]



ALISHA JUCEVIC CalMatters

INSURANCE Commissioner Ricardo Lara is shown in 2022. Damage from the L.A.-area fires is expected to cost insurers as much as \$45 billion.

Trump gearing up to wage war against cartels

Drone flights and terrorist designations are part of militaristic stance toward Mexico.

By MICHAEL WILNER, KATE LINTHICUM AND PATRICK J. McDONNELL

WASHINGTON — In recent days, the Trump administration has ramped up CIA surveillance drone flights over Mexico, formally designated drug cartels as "foreign terrorist" groups and floated the possibility of deploying troops there to fight organized crime.

Mexico is "essentially run by the cartels," President Trump has said, insisting that the United States should "wage war" against them.

No administration in modern times has taken such a militaristic approach to Mexico, a U.S. ally that

Trump blames for producing the fentanyl that has killed hundreds of thousands of Americans. His stance upends recent U.S. policy, which emphasized beefing up the rule of law in Mexico, and stands at odds with Mexico's security strategy, which has veered away from the sort of fierce cartel confrontations that drove record levels of bloodshed.

Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum said Thursday that she will propose a constitutional reform aimed at protecting her nation's sovereignty — a move that comes amid growing fears of a U.S. incursion that many believe would only spark more violence.

"The Mexican people under no circumstances will accept interventions, meddling or whatever other act from abroad that would be harmful to the integrity, independence and sovereignty of the nation," she [See **Mexico**, A8]



CARLOS MORENO NurPhoto

MARINE CORPS forces patrol a U.S.-Mexico border area on Feb. 7 in San Diego during a deployment.

Bass says Crowley failed to warn her

L.A. mayor's criticism of fire chief appears certain to renew their tensions after disaster.

By DAKOTA SMITH

In the weeks since the Palisades fire, Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass has faced repeated questions about why she left for Ghana as warnings about dangerous winds grew increasingly worrisome.

This week, Bass and her office spoke out for the first time about her decision, putting the blame on Los Angeles Fire Department Chief Kristin Crowley and others for not warning her about the highly concerning weather forecasts.

"Before other major weather emergencies, the mayor — or at minimum, the mayor's chief of staff — has received a direct call from

the fire chief, flagging the severity of the situation. This time, that call never came," Bass spokesperson Zach Seidl said in a statement.

Crowley did not reach out to the mayor's chief deputy until Tuesday morning, Jan. 7, after the Palisades was already burning, Seidl said.

On Jan. 2, the National Weather Service warned on its X feed of the potential for "extreme fire weather conditions" beginning Jan. 7.

The agency's forecast escalated Jan. 3 to "major risk — take action" and "critical fire conditions." The next day, Bass left for Ghana as part of a presidential delegation.

By Jan. 6, the agency was blaring on X: "HEADS UP!!! A LIFE-THREATENING, DESTRUCTIVE, Wide-spread Windstorm is expected Tue afternoon-Weds morning."

The frightening wind forecasts, in a winter when [See **Blame**, A6]

Senate confirms Patel to lead FBI

Democrats had pointed to his lack of management experience and questioned his judgment. **NATION**, A4

Eviction shield for fire victims

L.A. County proposes temporary protections for affected renters. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Weather

Sunny and warm. L.A. Basin: 81/53. **B6**

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Can the Lakers regain footing?

Coach JJ Redick must make up for the team's flaws, Dylan Hernández writes. **SPORTS**, B10

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Inmate-ordered crimes and punishment

Will convictions of Aryan Brotherhood trio help if federal 'supermax' site won't?

By MATTHEW ORMSETH

As witness after witness testified that three Aryan Brotherhood members directed drug deals, shake-downs and murders from their California prison cells,

the question was not whether prosecutors would convict them — but whether doing so would prevent future crimes.

Kenneth Johnson, Francis Clement and John Stinson were already serving life sentences in the state system when a federal jury in Fresno convicted them last week of racketeering and other offenses.

During the trial, prosecutors made clear that California prisons are flooded

with contraband cellphones, which gang leaders use to control rackets inside and outside their lockups.

Witnesses testified to enjoying the use of phones and drugs smuggled in using drones or by corrupt staff. Authorities seized 4,109 phones across the California prison system in 2023, the most recent year for which data were available, according to a prison spokeswoman.

The U.S. Bureau of Pris-

ons offers stricter conditions. High-risk inmates are held in a so-called super-maximum security facility in Colorado where they have virtually no access to one another or the outside world.

Despite the convictions of Johnson, Clement and Stinson, it remains unclear whether they will leave California. They are currently held at the Fresno County Jail.

Stinson's attorney, Ken- [See **Prisons**, A5]



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